Personal Data Disaster Recovery Guide

Protecting Your Digital Life Before Disaster Strikes

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Introduction

For most people, a backup for their data is an afterthought. We trick ourselves into thinking that we are immune from chaos.

“Data loss won't happen to me. That’s what happens to other people.”

“I don’t have enough juicy data to be a target for a ransomware attack.”

“I don’t change my password but the password I use is really hard to guess.”

Most people do not think about backups until something has already gone wrong.

A laptop suddenly stops working. A phone is lost. An online account is compromised. A hard drive fails without warning. Sometimes entire homes are affected by theft, fire, flooding, or severe weather.

Now what?

When these events occur, people often discover that years of family photos, important documents, financial records, and account information exist in only one place. Recovering those files can be expensive, difficult, or impossible.

Don’t freak out. I’ve got good news. Protecting your digital life does not require advanced technical skills. You do not need to be ready to “hack the Gibson” to take steps toward safeguarding your data. With a few simple tools and habits, anyone can significantly reduce the risk of losing important data.

This guide presents a practical approach to backup and recovery that works for most households. Whether you want a simple solution that takes only a few minutes to set up or a comprehensive disaster recovery strategy, you will find an approach that fits your needs.

Your goal is not perfection.

Your goal is that when something goes wrong, you will recover quickly and confidently.

Chapter 1:
The Foundation – The 3-2-1 Backup Rule

Before discussing software, cloud services, or backup devices, it is important to understand the single most important concept in data protection: **The 3-2-1 Backup Rule**.

The 3-2-1 Backup Rule has been used by IT professionals for decades because it is simple, effective, and easy to remember.

The Rule

The Rule says that you must maintain:

- **3 copies** of your data
- **2 different types** of storage media
- **1 copy stored offsite**

Don't worry. This sounds more complicated than it really is. Here is an example of the 3-2-1 Rule in use.

Example

Suppose you have a collection of family photos. You have them saved 1.) to your computer, 2.) on an external hard drive, and saved on a cloud storage system.

In this example:

- You have 3 copies.
- The copies exist on 2 different types of media.
- And 1 copy is stored away from your home.

This means that if your computer fails, your hard drive fails, or even if your home suffers a major disaster, your photos can still be recovered.

Technology and cloud services have made it so that IT pros and your average Joe's now have access to some incredibly powerful and accessible tools to put this rule to use. But why is this Rule so important? Why isn't a copy of my data, saved on my computer, enough? Why am I not covered having my data synced to my iCloud account? Because one copy of your data is never enough.

Why One Copy Is Never Enough

Many people believe their files are safe because they store them on a laptop or desktop computer. Or, you've paid for a Google One account and all of your contents are stored in the cloud. Maybe you rely on the 1TB of storage on your phone.

Unfortunately, computers fail. Hard drives fail. Phones are lost. Accounts are locked.

Mistakes happen.

Any device can become inaccessible with little warning.

If important information exists in only one location, losing that location may mean losing the data forever.

Here's a real life example of a bad situation becoming worse and being saved by The 3-2-1 Backup Rule:

I had a laptop that I used for college. I wrote all of my papers on that machine and printed them when I needed a copy for class (this was in the early 2000's when hard copies were still required).

I had a thumb drive that I also saved my important documents to because I was a mega nerd and knew that bad things happen to good nerds. I also maintained a cloud storage account on two different platforms.

Well, lightning struck (literally) and an electrical surge destroyed my laptop. The attached thumb drive was also cooked. What wonderful luck that I had a cloud account to call on for my data. I was able to retrieve a copy of a paper I was working on and was able to get everything restored with minimal effort.

The Goal of a Backup

A backup is not simply another place where files are stored. A backup is a copy that can be used to restore data when something goes wrong. The difference matters.

If a file becomes corrupted, accidentally deleted, encrypted by ransomware, or lost during a hardware failure, a proper backup provides a path to recovery. These things sound like they are "rare cases" or that they're "not likely to happen" to the average user.

In my long time in IT, I can tell you that I have heard hundreds of horror stories and experienced my fair share of freak occurrences.

Having a backup solution in place is the difference between a few minutes of downtime and a few days spent trying to figure out what you might have left. But what strategy best fits your life and level of tech experience?

Every strategy described in this guide is built on the 3-2-1 principle and provides explanations on how to implement the plan that's right for you.

Chapter 2:
The Three Backup Tiers

Not everyone needs (or wants) the same level of protection.

Some people simply want to ensure they can recover passwords and family photos.

Others want protection against hardware failures, ransomware, or even major disasters.

A “one size fits all” approach is almost never the go to method in tech. It certainly holds true for creating backups.

For that reason, this guide introduces three tiers of backup effort:

MINimum, **MID**dle & **MAX**imum levels of backup solutions. Three tiers of readiness to suit any personal user's needs.

MIN Tier (The Minimum Effort Approach)

The MIN Tier is designed for people who want the greatest benefit with the least effort.

This approach focuses on:

- Cloud storage
- A password manager
- Multi-factor authentication

Setup typically requires less than one hour and provides protection against many common problems (i.e. hardware failure, forgotten passwords, hacked/ stolen accounts).

This is the minimum level of preparedness recommended for every household.

MID Tier (The Middle of the Road Approach)

The MID Tier builds on the MIN Tier.

It adds:

- Automatic local backups
- External storage devices
- Additional cloud capacity

This tier provides stronger protection against hardware failures, accidental deletion, and ransomware incidents.

For many families, the MID Tier represents the ideal balance between cost, effort, and protection.

MAX Tier (“MAXIMUM EFFORT!” - Deadpool)

The MAX Tier is designed for users who want the highest level of resilience.

This approach includes:

- Full adherence to the 3-2-1 rule
- Encrypted backup storage
- Regular recovery testing
- Detailed asset inventories

While it requires more effort, it provides the greatest protection against catastrophic events.

A Note for the Reader: Start Small

One of the biggest mistakes people make is trying to build a perfect backup system on the first day.

A simple backup system that is actually used is far better than a complicated system that is abandoned after a week.

If you are new to backups, start with the MIN Tier.

You can always improve your system later.

If you’re feeling confident and feel like you can take on the MAX Tier, apply the first two tiers first. See how that goes and when, if those practices are a good fit, try to round out your setup with the higher tier projects.

Take your time and build something that is sustainable and useful.

Chapter 3: MIN Tier

The Minimum Protection Every Household Should Have

The MIN Tier focuses on protecting the information that causes the most stress when it is lost:

- Passwords
- Email accounts
- Financial accounts
- Personal documents
- Family photos

This tier requires only three components:

1. Cloud storage
2. A password manager
3. Multi-factor authentication

Together, these tools provide protection against many of the most common digital disasters.

Component One:

Cloud Storage

Cloud storage keeps a copy of your files on secure servers maintained by a service provider.

Popular options include:

- Google Drive
- Microsoft OneDrive
- Apple iCloud

Cloud storage offers several benefits:

- Files are synchronized automatically.
- Files can be accessed from multiple devices.
- Data remains available if a computer is lost or damaged.

For most users, any major cloud provider is acceptable.

The best choice is often the service that already integrates with your devices.

What Cloud Storage Does Not Replace

Cloud storage is important, but it is not a complete backup strategy.

If files are accidentally deleted or encrypted by malware, those changes may also synchronize to the cloud.

This is why additional backup layers become important in the MID and MAX tiers.

Component Two:
Password Management

Many people reuse the same password for multiple accounts.

This creates significant risk. I cannot overstate the importance of using different passwords for different systems.

If a single website experiences a security breach, attackers may attempt to use the same password to access email, banking, shopping, and social media accounts. This is one of the first attack points that a bad actor will explore when scoping out their target.

A password manager solves this problem.

Why Bitwarden?

Bitwarden allows users to:

- Generate strong passwords
- Store passwords securely
- Synchronize passwords across devices
- Share passwords with family members when needed

Instead of remembering dozens of passwords, users only need to remember one master password.

The Most Important Password

Your Bitwarden master password protects everything else.

Choose a password that is:

- Long
- Unique
- Easy for you to remember
- Difficult for others to guess

A passphrase consisting of several unrelated words is often easier to remember and more secure than a short, complex password.

Example:

Correct-Horse-Lemon-Bridge-1978

Do not reuse an existing password as your master password.

Component Three:
Multi-Factor Authentication

Passwords alone are no longer enough.

Multi-factor authentication (MFA), sometimes called two-factor authentication (2FA), adds an additional layer of security.

When enabled, a second verification step is required before an account can be accessed.

Common methods include:

- Authenticator apps
- Security keys
- SMS text messages

Authenticator applications are generally preferred because they provide stronger protection than text messages.

Priority Accounts

If you only enable multi-factor authentication on a few accounts, start with:

1. Email
2. Password Manager
3. Banking Accounts

These accounts provide access to many other parts of your digital life and should receive the highest level of protection.

MIN Tier Summary

By completing the MIN Tier, you gain protection against:

✓ Password reuse

✓ Account compromise

✓ Device loss

✓ Forgotten passwords

✓ Loss of access to important accounts

For many people, completing the MIN Tier represents the single largest improvement they can make to their digital preparedness.

The total time it would take to setup the MIN Tier is about 1 hour. That hour is a small price to pay for peace of mind and sustainable security.

Chapter 4:
MID Tier

Better Protection with Minimal Additional Effort

The MIN Tier provides protection for passwords, accounts, and important files. For many people, that level of protection is already a significant improvement.

However, the MIN Tier does not solve for all problems:

> What happens if your computer's hard drive fails?
>
> What happens if you accidentally delete an important folder?
>
> What happens if ransomware encrypts your files?

Cloud storage can help in some situations, but it should not be your only line of defense.

The MID Tier adds automatic local backups and additional cloud protection, creating a system that can recover from many common failures.

For most households, the MID Tier offers the best balance between cost, effort, and protection.

What You Need

The MID Tier includes everything from the MIN Tier plus:

- An external hard drive
- Automatic backup software
- Additional cloud storage capacity

The goal is simple:

Create an additional copy of your files that is physically separate from your computer and updated automatically.

Choosing an External Hard Drive

An external drive is one of the most cost-effective ways to improve your backup strategy.

If you are like me, you have 10+ years of family photos and documents to safeguard. That can mean A LOT of data to store and keep secure. For most users, a drive with 2 to 4 terabytes of storage is sufficient.

You may encounter two common types of external drives:

Hard Disk Drives (HDD)

Hard disk drives contain stacked magnetic disks that carry a system's data, even when power is not being delivered to the system.

Advantages:

- Lower cost
- Large storage capacity

Disadvantages:

- Slower performance
- More vulnerable to physical damage

Solid State Drives (SSD)

Solid State Drives use flash memory (similar to a USB thumb drive), relying on integrated circuits and not on moving mechanical parts (like the HDD).

Advantages:

- Faster performance
- More durable
- Smaller and lighter

Disadvantages:

- Higher cost

Either option is suitable for backups.

The most important factor is consistently using the drive.

For me, performance and a smaller physical footprint is important. For those reasons, a SSD is used as my primary backup method. I do, however, use several HDD for secondary, short-term backup methods.

Automatic Backups on Windows

Windows includes a feature called File History that can automatically copy files to an external drive.

Step 1: Connect your external drive.

Step 2: Open Settings.

Step 3: Navigate to:

System → Storage → Advanced Storage Settings → Backup Options

Step 4: Select your external drive.

Step 5: Enable automatic backups.

Once configured, Windows will periodically save copies of files in your Documents, Pictures, Videos, and Desktop folders.

You no longer need to remember to perform backups manually.

This is such a simple system to put in place and so many Windows users do not even know that this function exists. You don't need to download anything additional to put this automatic file backup in place.

Automatic Backups on Mac

Mac computers include a built-in backup system called Time Machine. Time Machine is one of the easiest backup systems available to consumers.

Step 1: Connect an external drive.

Step 2: Open System Settings.

Step 3: Select General → Time Machine.

Step 4: Choose the external drive.

Step 5: Enable automatic backups.

Time Machine automatically creates historical versions of files and allows users to restore individual files or entire systems. It is effective and it doesn't require a technically adept user to operate.

Expanding Cloud Storage

Many users quickly outgrow the free storage provided by cloud providers.

A subscription service can provide:

- More storage space
- Device backups
- Additional recovery features
- Family sharing options

The purpose is not to replace local backups but to create another recovery option.

Remember:

- Cloud storage is one layer.
- Local backups are another.
- Together they provide stronger protection than either solution alone.

What the MID Tier Protects Against

The MID Tier can help recover from:

✓ Hard drive failure

✓ Accidental file deletion

✓ Lost or stolen devices

✓ Operating system corruption

✓ Many ransomware incidents

✓ Hardware replacement scenarios

For many households, this level of protection is sufficient for everyday life.

Chapter 5:
MAX Tier

Comprehensive Disaster Recovery

The MAX Tier is designed for individuals who want the highest level of protection for their digital life.

This tier is not about convenience. It is about resilience.

The goal is to maintain access to important information even after catastrophic events, such as::

- Fire
- Flood
- Tornado
- Burglary
- Multiple device failures
- Severe ransomware incidents

The MAX Tier builds on everything from the MIN and MID tiers.

Strict 3-2-1 Compliance

At this level, the 3-2-1 Rule becomes a deliberate requirement.

Example:

Copy #1: Primary computer

Copy #2: External backup drive

Copy #3: Cloud backup

Each copy should be maintained independently.

The failure of any single component should not prevent recovery.

Encrypted Backup Storage

Backups often contain sensitive information:

- Tax returns
- Insurance documents
- Medical records
- Financial statements
- Identity documents

If an external drive is lost or stolen, anyone who gains access to the drive may be able to view its contents.

Encryption helps solve this problem.

Understanding Encryption

Encryption converts readable data into unreadable information that can only be accessed with the correct password or key.

Without the password, the contents remain protected.

Think of encryption as a digital safe. The files remain present, but unauthorized users cannot access them.

Using VeraCrypt

VeraCrypt allows users to create encrypted storage containers. These containers function like secure vaults.

When unlocked with the correct password, files can be added or removed normally.

When locked, the contents remain inaccessible.

Best practices include:

- Use a strong password
- Store recovery information securely
- Test access regularly
- Maintain a second copy of critical encrypted files

VeraCrypt is also a great option because it works on Windows, Mac, and Linux.

Quarterly Restore Testing

One of the most common backup mistakes is never testing recovery. A backup that has never been tested should not be assumed to work.

At least once every three months:

1. Select a file.
2. Delete the local copy.
3. Restore it from backup.
4. Verify that it opens correctly.

This simple exercise confirms that your recovery process works before an actual emergency occurs. Verifying that you have a complete backup before a failure event is important. It tells you that you have a copy of data that you can rely on.

Creating a Home Inventory

Many disasters affect more than digital files.

A home inventory helps document possessions for insurance claims and recovery efforts.

Consider recording:

- Computers
- Phones
- Tablets
- Televisions
- Appliances
- Jewelry
- Firearms
- Collectibles

For each item, document:

- Make and model
- Serial number
- Purchase date
- Approximate value
- Photographs

Store inventory records in your backup system.

There is no need to over complicate things. The list can be a spreadsheet or a simple text document.

PRO TIP: Use a cloud system that you already have in place, like Google Drive, to store a copy of your inventory. I have an inventory stored in a Google Sheet on my Google Drive account. This allows me to access my inventory from any device, at any time.

Advanced Option: Network Attached Storage (NAS)

Some users may wish to centralize backups using a Network Attached Storage device.

A NAS is essentially a specialized computer dedicated to storing files and backups.

Benefits include:

- Centralized storage
- Multiple device backups
- Remote access
- Larger storage capacity

A NAS is not required for a strong backup strategy.

However, advanced users often use NAS devices as part of a broader 3-2-1 implementation.

Examples include systems from Synology and QNAP, as well as software platforms such as TrueNAS. A NAS is something that you are more likely to encounter in a business environment (or in the home lab of a super nerd).

What the MAX Tier Protects Against

✓ Fire

✓ Flood

✓ Theft

✓ Hardware failure

✓ Multiple device loss

✓ Ransomware

✓ Major household disasters

✓ Long-term recovery scenarios

The MAX Tier provides the greatest level of confidence that important information can be recovered regardless of the circumstances.

Chapter 6:
Password Managers: Bitwarden Deep Dive

Why This Chapter Matters

When people think about disaster recovery, they often focus on files.

In reality, the most difficult thing to recover is frequent access. Without access to email accounts, cloud storage, banking services, and online accounts, recovering data becomes far more difficult.

Your password manager is often the key that unlocks everything else.

For that reason, it deserves special attention.

Understanding the Password Problem

Most people manage passwords in one of four ways:

- Reusing the same password everywhere
- Writing passwords on paper
- Saving passwords in browsers only
- Attempting to memorize dozens of passwords

All of these approaches create risk. Modern users often have hundreds of online accounts. Managing them manually is unrealistic.

What Bitwarden Does

Bitwarden securely stores:

- Usernames
- Passwords
- Credit cards
- Secure notes
- Identity information

Instead of remembering dozens of passwords, users only need to remember one master password. The software handles the rest.

Creating Your Vault

Think of your Bitwarden vault as a digital safe. Everything stored inside should be considered important.

Examples include:

- Email passwords
- Banking credentials
- Insurance information
- Wi-Fi passwords
- Recovery codes
- Important account notes

Over time, the vault becomes one of the most valuable resources in your digital life.

Browser Extensions

Installing the Bitwarden browser extension dramatically improves usability.

The extension can:

- Save new passwords
- Fill login forms
- Generate secure passwords
- Update existing entries

Most users interact with Bitwarden primarily through the browser extension.

More and more, it is becoming clear that relying on the browser password manager, like the one built into Chrome, is an attack vector that bad actors are exploiting more and more. Employing Bitwarden and the Bitwarden browser extension is an effective countermeasure to this easily exploitable security weak point.

Mobile Applications

Install Bitwarden on your phone as soon as possible.

This ensures access to passwords and data across platforms.

Modern mobile versions support:

- Fingerprint unlock
- Face recognition
- Secure autofill

These features make strong passwords practical without sacrificing convenience.

Migrating Existing Passwords

One of the most common concerns people have when adopting a password manager is:

> "What happens to all of my existing passwords?"

The good news is that most users can migrate their saved passwords in less than an hour.

If you have previously allowed your browser to save passwords, there is a good chance that many of your existing credentials can be imported directly into Bitwarden.

Before You Begin

Before importing passwords:

1. Create your Bitwarden account.
2. Verify that you can log in successfully.
3. Install the browser extension.
4. Record your master password in a secure location.

Do not begin migrating passwords until you are confident that you can access your Bitwarden vault.

Exporting Passwords from Chrome

Google Chrome allows users to export saved passwords.

Typical process:

1. Open Chrome Settings.
2. Select Password Manager.
3. Locate Saved Passwords.
4. Export passwords.
5. Save the export file temporarily.

The exported file contains unencrypted passwords.

Treat it carefully.

Anyone who obtains the file can view its contents.

Importing into Bitwarden

Once passwords have been exported:

1. Log into Bitwarden.
2. Open Tools.
3. Select Import Data.
4. Choose the appropriate format.
5. Import the file.

After importing:

- Review entries for accuracy.
- Remove duplicate records.
- Verify important accounts.

Once successful, securely delete the exported password file.

Leaving the export file on your computer defeats much of the security benefit of using a password manager.

Cleaning Up Weak Passwords

Importing passwords is only the first step.

Many users discover they have:

- Duplicate passwords
- Weak passwords
- Old accounts
- Unused credentials

Plan to gradually improve your vault over time.

You do not need to update every password immediately.

Instead:

1. Start with email accounts.
2. Continue with banking accounts.
3. Update shopping accounts.
4. Update social media accounts.
5. Address remaining accounts over time.

Progress is more important than perfection.

Creating Strong Passwords

One of the biggest advantages of Bitwarden is password generation.

When creating a new account:

- Let Bitwarden generate the password.
- Do not attempt to memorize it.
- Save it to the vault immediately.

Strong passwords should be:

- Long
- Unique
- Random

A password manager allows you to use a different password for every account without increasing complexity.

Organizing Your Vault

As the number of stored items grows, organization becomes important.

Consider creating folders such as:

Financial

- Banks
- Credit cards
- Investments

Shopping

- Amazon
- Retailers
- Subscription services

Utilities

- Internet provider
- Electricity
- Water
- Mobile phone carrier

Family

- Shared household accounts
- Streaming services
- Insurance information

Storing Secure Notes

Many people focus only on passwords. However, secure notes can be equally valuable.

Examples include:

- Alarm codes
- Wi-Fi passwords
- Insurance policy numbers
- Recovery procedures
- Important contact information

Think about the information you would need if your primary computer disappeared tomorrow. That information often belongs in secure notes.

Emergency Access

One of the most overlooked features of password managers is emergency access.

Consider the following scenario:

A spouse manages all household accounts. Something unexpected happens. The other spouse suddenly needs access to:

- Banking
- Utilities
- Insurance
- Investments
- Medical portals

Without preparation, this process can become extremely difficult. Emergency access allows trusted individuals to obtain access when necessary while preserving privacy during normal circumstances.

Family Sharing

Families often share access to:

- Streaming services
- Utility providers
- Insurance portals
- Tax preparation software
- Home maintenance accounts

A family plan allows selected credentials to be shared without revealing every password in the vault. This creates a healthier balance between convenience and security.

Instead of texting passwords or writing them down, credentials can be maintained in a secure and controlled manner.

What If Bitwarden Is Hacked?

This is one of the most common questions new users ask. Password managers are designed around the assumption that attackers may eventually gain access to stored data.

Bitwarden uses strong encryption to protect vault contents. More importantly, your master password is never known to Bitwarden.

This means:

- Bitwarden cannot recover your master password.
- Employees cannot view your vault.
- Attackers cannot easily access vault contents without the master password.

The security of your vault ultimately depends on the strength of your master password and whether multi-factor authentication is enabled.

What If I Forget My Master Password?

Unlike many online services, password managers generally cannot reset or recover a forgotten master password. This design improves security but places responsibility on the user.

Recommendations:

- Create a memorable passphrase.
- Write it down initially.
- Store it securely.
- Consider a sealed emergency copy.

Losing your master password can result in losing access to your vault. Treat it seriously.

What If My Phone Is Lost?

Your passwords are not stored exclusively on the phone. The phone is simply another method of accessing the vault. This is one of the major benefits of cloud-synchronized password management.

If your phone is lost:

1. Obtain a replacement device.
2. Install Bitwarden.
3. Sign into your account.
4. Complete multi-factor authentication.
5. Access your vault.

Bitwarden Best Practices

1. Use a unique master password.
2. Enable multi-factor authentication.
3. Install Bitwarden on all primary devices.
4. Keep recovery information available.
5. Regularly review stored accounts.
6. Use generated passwords whenever possible.
7. Never reuse passwords across sites.

These habits provide a strong foundation for account security and disaster recovery.

Chapter 7:

Final Thoughts

Disaster recovery is not about technology. It is about preparation.

The goal is not to create a perfect system. The goal is to ensure that important memories, documents, and accounts remain available when they are needed most.

Every improvement matters:

- A simple backup is better than no backup.
- A tested backup is better than an untested backup.
- A recovery plan that exists before a disaster is infinitely better than trying to create one during an emergency.

Start with the MIN Tier, build toward the MID Tier, and adopt MAX Tier practices as your needs grow.

Most importantly, begin today.

I learned the hard way that waiting to implement backup measures is a recipe for devastation. Your vacation pictures from 8 years ago cannot be recreated. You need to ensure that the systems for recovery are in place before they are needed.

WORKSHEETS

The pages that follow are meant to work as a set of useful documents that you can print out and work from in the event of a system failure or catastrophic event.

Please utilize these forms when in the process of setting up your recovery system or executing a disaster recovery scenario.

EMERGENCY DIGITAL RECOVERY CHECKLIST

What To Do If Your Computer, Phone, or Home Is Lost, Damaged, or Stolen

Keep this page with your important documents.
Review it at least once per year.

BEFORE A DISASTER

Complete these items now:

☐ **Use a password manager (Bitwarden)**

☐ **Enable two-factor authentication (2FA) on:**

- **Email**
- **Banking**
- **Password manager**

☐ **Enable cloud backup for important files and photos**

☐ **Configure automatic computer backups**

☐ **Test restoring a file from backup**

☐ **Record emergency contact information**

☐ **Store this checklist in a safe location**

IF A DEVICE IS LOST, STOLEN, OR DESTROYED

STEP 1 — STAY CALM

Most information can be recovered if proper backups exist. Focus on restoring access first.

STEP 2 — OBTAIN A SAFE DEVICE

Avoid public computers whenever possible. Instead, use:

- ☐ Replacement computer
- ☐ Replacement phone
- ☐ Trusted family member's device

STEP 3 — RECOVER EMAIL ACCESS

Your email account is key to recovery.
Verify access to:

- ☐ Primary email account
- ☐ Recovery email account

If access is unavailable:

- ☐ Begin account recovery process
- ☐ Contact provider support if necessary

STEP 4 — RESTORE PASSWORD MANAGER ACCESS

Install Bitwarden. Sign in using:

- ☐ Email address
- ☐ Master password
- ☐ Two-factor authentication

Once Bitwarden access is restored, most account recovery becomes significantly easier.

STEP 5 — SECURE IMPORTANT ACCOUNTS

Review and secure:

- ☐ Email
- ☐ Banking
- ☐ Credit cards
- ☐ Investment acct.
- ☐ Insurance acct.
- ☐ Mobile carrier
- ☐ Cloud storage

If theft or compromise is suspected:

- ☐ Change passwords
- ☐ Sign out old devices
- ☐ Review account activity

STEP 6 — RESTORE FILES

Recover data from:

- ☐ Cloud storage
- ☐ External hard drive
- ☐ Time Machine (Mac)
- ☐ File History (Windows)
- ☐ NAS (if applicable)

Verify:

- ☐ Documents open correctly
- ☐ Photos are present
- ☐ Important records are accessible

STEP 7 — RE-ENABLE PROTECTION ON REPLACEMENT DEVICES

- ☐ Install Bitwarden
- ☐ Enable cloud backup
- ☐ Configure automatic backups
- ☐ Enable two-factor authentication
- ☐ Install security updates

EMERGENCY INFORMATION

Primary Email:

Recovery Email:

Bitwarden Account Email:

Cloud Storage Provider:

Backup Drive Location:

Trusted Emergency Contact:

Phone:

Emergency Recovery Checklist

Step 1: Obtain a Trusted Device

Acquire:
- A replacement computer
- A replacement phone
- Or a trusted temporary device

Avoid using public computers whenever possible.

Step 2: Recover Email Access

Verify access to:
- Primary email
- Recovery email

If access is unavailable:
- Use account recovery options.
- Contact the provider if necessary.

Step 3: Install Your Password Manager

Install Bitwarden.
Sign in using:
- Email address
- Master password
- Multi-factor authentication

Step 4: Verify Critical Accounts

Confirm access to:

□ Primary email
□ Secondary email
□ Banking
□ Credit cards
□ Investments
□ Insurance
□ Mobile carrier
□ Cloud storage

Step 5: Secure Your Accounts

If devices were stolen or compromised:
- Change important passwords.
- Review recent account activity.
- Sign out of old devices.
- Update recovery information.

Step 6: Restore Cloud Data

Access your cloud provider. Restore:

□ Documents
□ Photos
□ Videos
□ Important records

Step 7: Restore Local Backups

Restore the most recent backup set.

1. Documents
2. Financial records
3. Photos
4. Personal files

Step 8: Reconfigure Automatic Backups

New devices should immediately be configured for:
□ Cloud synchronization
□ Local backups
□ Password manager access
□ Multi-factor authentication

Step 9: Review Important Documents

Verify access to:
□ Insurance policies
□ Tax records
□ Estate planning documents
□ Home inventory
□ Identification documents

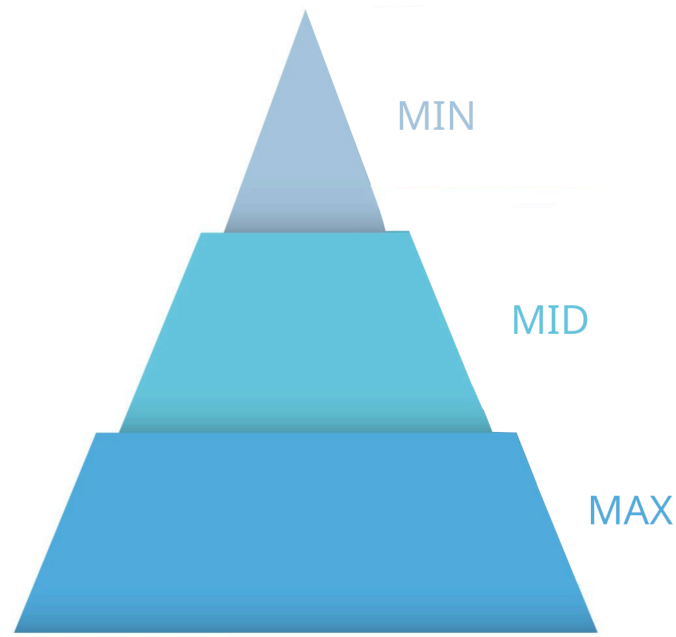
Store recovered copies in multiple locations.

Step 10: Schedule a Recovery Test

Within the next 30 days:
- Restore a file.
- Test a backup.
- Verify account access.

The best time to discover a problem is before the next emergency.

MIN Tier (Minimum)



The MIN Tier is designed for people who want the greatest benefit with the least effort.

This approach focuses on:

- Cloud storage
- A password manager
- Multi-factor authentication

Setup typically requires less than one hour and provides protection against many common problems (i.e. hardware failure, forgotten passwords, hacked/ stolen accounts).

This is the minimum level of preparedness recommended for every household.

MID Tier (Middle)

The MID Tier builds on the MIN Tier, but adds:

- Automatic local backups
- External storage devices
- Additional cloud capacity

This tier provides stronger protection against hardware failures, accidental deletion, and ransomware incidents. It represents the ideal balance between cost, effort, and protection.

MAX Tier (Maximum)

The MAX Tier is designed for users who want the highest level of resilience.

This approach includes:

- Full adherence to the 3-2-1 rule
- Encrypted backup storage
- Regular recovery testing
- Detailed asset inventories

While it requires more effort, it provides the greatest protection against catastrophic events.